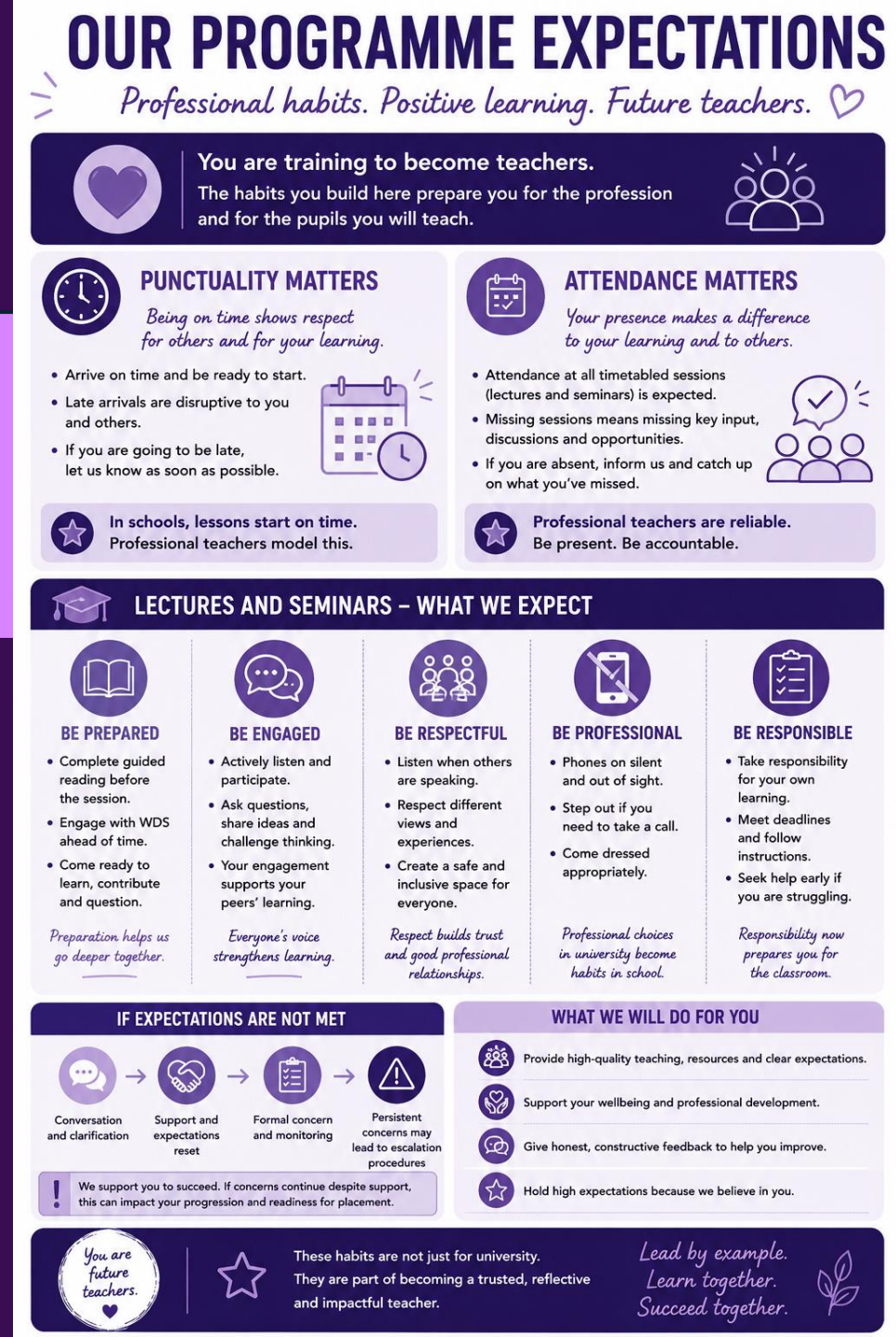
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Module: Principles of Learning & Curriculum Design

Assignment launch

Dr Rhonwen Bruce, PGCE Secondary Programme Leader and PGCE Secondary History Course Leader



How ITaP 1: Professionalism feeds into the assignment

Professionalism is not separate from curriculum design it shapes the decisions you make and how you justify them.

PROFESSIONAL JUDGEMENT

Your sequence contains choices: what to teach, what to omit, how to sequence it and how to respond to pupils.

ASSIGNMENT LINK:Make those decisions visible and justify why they are defensible.

RESEARCH-INFORMED PRACTICE

A professional teacher does not simply follow a strategy because it is popular or familiar.

ASSIGNMENT LINK: Use research to support, critique and refine your pedagogical and curriculum choices.

SUBJECT RESPONSIBILITY

You are responsible for the integrity of what pupils encounter in your subject: knowledge, disciplinary thinking and curriculum framing.

ASSIGNMENT LINK: Explain what is distinctive about learning in your subject and why this sequence matters.

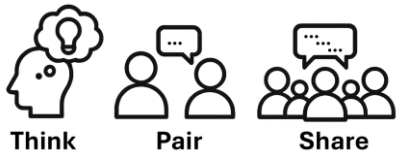
INCLUSION AND HIGH EXPECTATIONS

Professionalism means anticipating barriers while maintaining ambitious learning for pupils.

ASSIGNMENT LINK: Analyse adaptations, representation and access without lowering the intellectual goal.

Keep asking: What professional decision am I making here and what evidence makes it defensible?

Starter: Think, Pair, Share



SEQUENCE A

Lesson 1: Introduce the topic
Lesson 2: New content
Lesson 3: Different activity
Lesson 4: Assessment
Lesson 5: Revision

SEQUENCE B

Lesson 1: Establish prior knowledge and core idea
Lesson 2: Build and connect
Lesson 3: Apply in a new context
Lesson 4: Deepen + address misconceptions
Lesson 5: Synthesise and assess

Which sequence looks more coherent and what makes you say that?

Think about lessons you've experienced (as learners or within a school role).

- What made them feel *joined-up*?
- What made them feel *disjointed*?

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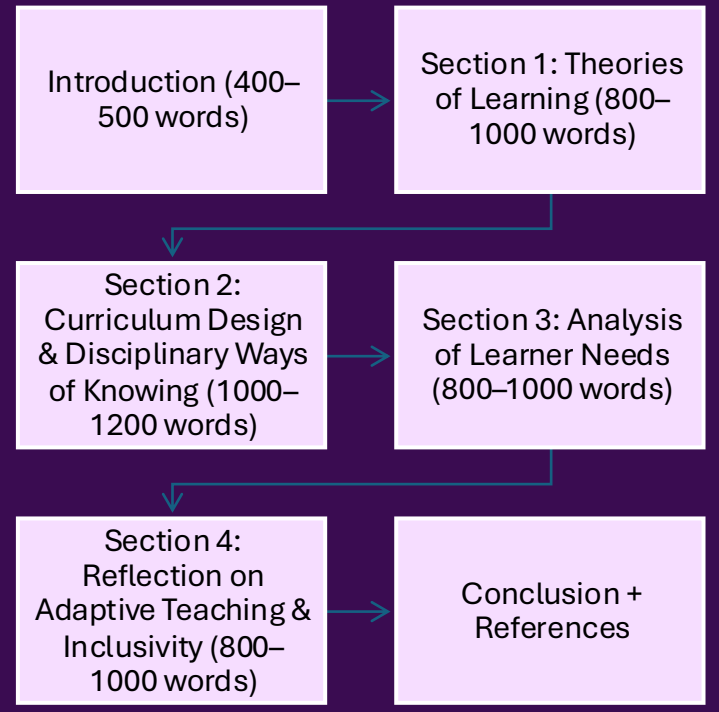
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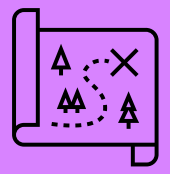
That judgement is the heart of the assignment

MAKE A DECISION → JUSTIFY IT → CRITIQUE IT → REFINE IT

The assignment is not a test of how many theorists you can name.

It asks you to use research, theory and subject pedagogy to explain why your sequence is educationally defensible.





Overview of the assignment

4,000-word written rationale **AND** **4–6 lesson sequence**

1. LEARNING

How do pupils learn and what does that mean for your choices?

2. CURRICULUM

What should be taught, in what order, and why?

3. LEARNERS

What needs, barriers and starting points matter?

4. INCLUSION

How will you adapt while maintaining ambition?

You are not expected to know all of this today

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Your PGCE curriculum will build towards the assignment.

1 HOW PUPILS LEARN

- Memory
- Cognitive psychology (Willingham, Sweller, Rosenshine, Bjork, Hattie & Yates)
- Metacognition
- Constructivism/social learning (Vygotsky, Bruner)
- Curriculum thinkers (Young, Myatt, Counsell)
- Philosophical/critical thinkers (Biesta, Alexander, Freire, hooks, Noddings)

2 CURRICULUM AND SUBJECT

- Disciplinary ways of knowing (substantive, conceptual, procedural knowledge)
- Why this topic? Why now?
- Sequencing for progression (Bruner, Counsell, Fordham)
- Curriculum models (spiral, backward design, coherence)

3 PLANNING AND TEACHING

- Modelling
- Explanation
- scaffolding

4 INCLUSION

- SEND
- EAL
- Socio-economic and cultural context
- Adaptation
- Challenge
- Representation

5 ASSESSMENT

- checking learning
- Feedback
- responsive teaching



TODAY: understand the destination → **NEXT FEW WEEKS: collect lenses and evidence** → **ASSIGNMENT: bring them together**



Every PGCE session gives you something to further explore for the assignment

SESSIONS	QUESTION TO CARRY WITH YOU	ASSIGNMENT LINK
How pupils learn [week3]	What does this suggest about how I design learning? Metacognition? Cognitive Psychology? Constructivism?	Learning theory
Curriculum and subject seminars	What form of knowledge? Why this knowledge? Why now? What is distinctive in my subject?	Curriculum / disciplinary
Planning, modelling and scaffolding [week 4]	How will lessons build learning rather than just activity? Chunking? Dual-coding?	Sequence / pedagogy
Inclusion and adaptive teaching [week 4]	What barriers might pupils encounter without lowering expectations? How are pupils represented in your sequence of lessons?	Learner needs
Assessment and feedback	How will I know whether pupils learned what I intended? Retrieval practice? Questioning?	Evaluation

Level 7: move from ‘name-dropping’ to reasoning

WEAKER

“Vygotsky says…”

Social interaction is important, so I will use group work.

STRONGER

Vygotsky (1978) positions learning as fundamentally social; research on classroom talk suggests, however, that dialogue supports learning most effectively when it is purposeful and structured (Mercer & Littleton, 2007; Alexander, 2020). Therefore, the sequence will…

CLAIM → EVIDENCE → CRITIQUE / QUALIFY → DECISION → IMPACT

Turn to your shoulder partner: what makes the second response more convincing?

Spot the Difference
Strong vs Weak Writing

- **Weak Extract (descriptive only):**
  "Bruner said that knowledge should be organised in a spiral curriculum. This means topics are repeated and revisited. It helps students to remember more."

- **Strong Extract (critical and applied):**
  "Bruner's (1960) spiral curriculum proposes that understanding can be developed by revisiting important concepts at increasing levels of complexity. However, Bruner's theoretical account does not, in itself, establish that repeated encounters will secure progression, nor does it specify precisely how progression should be conceptualised within individual school subjects. Fordham (2016) similarly cautions against equating recurrence with increasingly sophisticated disciplinary understanding. The lesson sequence will therefore revisit the concept of narrative voice through progressively more demanding texts and analytical tasks, with each encounter deliberately extending pupils' prior understanding rather than simply repeating content."

Turn to your shoulder partner and identify one thing that makes the stronger extract better

CLAIM: What does the research/theory suggest?
CRITIQUE: What are its limitations? What does it *not* establish?
QUALIFY: What does other scholarship add or challenge?
DECISION: What will therefore be done?
IMPACT: How should this improve or deepen pupils' learning?

Your subject matters

A generic lesson sequence is not enough.

WHAT?

What knowledge, concepts or practices matter in your subject?

WHY THIS?

Why is this content worth pupils knowing?

WHY NOW?

What prior knowledge does it depend on? What will it enable later?

HOW?

What does effective teaching and learning look like in this discipline?

Your subject seminars are therefore assignment preparation too.

Inclusion: analyse, don't label

Not: “Pupils with X need strategy Y.”

Instead ask:

- What might create a barrier in this particular learning?
- What does this pupil already know and need?
- How can support increase access without reducing intellectual challenge?
- What are the risks or limitations of the adaptation?
- How will I know whether it is working?

Adaptive teaching is a reasoned response to learners not a checklist of diagnoses.

Build an ‘assignment passport’ over the next few weeks

1 LEARNING

How pupils learn

2 CURRICULUM

What / why / sequence

3 SUBJECT

What is distinctive

4 INCLUSION

Barriers and adaptation

5 ASSESSMENT

Evidence of learning

6 EVIDENCE

Research worth keeping

You do not fill this today. Keep adding to it as the PGCE curriculum unfolds.



Your first three moves

Do these before you worry about writing 4,000 words.

1 IDENTIFY

- Choose / clarify the 4–6 lesson sequence you will work with.
- What is the learning journey?

2 NOTICE

- Mark the decisions that need justification.
- Why this content? Why this order? Why this approach?

3 READ

- Read around those decisions.
- Use the reading template to capture argument, critique and application.

Targeted reading beats random reading.



What Makes a Good Lesson Sequence?

What Makes a Lesson Sequence Feel *Joined-Up*

- Clear learning goals that link across lessons.
- Logical progression (each lesson builds on the last).
- Retrieval or recap of prior learning at the start.
- Explicit links between topics ("last time we learned X, now we'll apply it to Y").
- Appropriate scaffolding that reduces over time.
- Opportunities to apply knowledge/skills in different contexts.
- Balance of knowledge and skills (not just content coverage).
- Consistent routines and expectations.

What Makes a Lesson Sequence Feel *Disjointed*

- Lessons feel like stand-alone events with no connection.
- Sudden jumps in difficulty without preparation.
- Too much content crammed in without consolidation.
- No revisiting or retrieval of earlier learning.
- Activities that don't clearly link to learning outcomes.
- Inconsistent teaching approaches (no continuity).
- Students unsure of *why* they are learning a topic.
- Lack of progression (repetition without deepening).

Your sequence needs to be submitted as an appendix [see template on BB]. You can also submit lesson plans, resources to support your claims in the assignment. They MUST be referred to e.g. … "In appendix A…"

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PGCE Assignment Submission Deadline Dates 2026-2027 (for Bb)

Assignment Name and Module Code	Assessment Type	Word Count	Assignment Submission Deadline Date (by 9AM)	Tutor Feedback Date (by 4.00pm)	In-year reassessment opportunity Deadline Date (by 9AM)	Tutor Feedback Date
Principles of Learning and Curriculum Design	Written Assignment (100%)	4000 words	18th November 2026	16th December 2026	27th January 2027	16th December 2026
Evidence-Informed Practice	Written Assignment [60%] and Academic Poster [40%]	Written assignment: 3000 words Academic poster: Up to 2000 words	17th March 2027	14th April 2027	12th May 2027	14th April 2027

Support & Resources



WEEKLY Reading template on BB:

Organises reading efficiently, captures key ideas, citations and assignment links in one place, making sources easier to revisit when writing.

Develops Level 7 critical thinking

Connects research to practice



EEF GUIDANCE REPORTS



SUBJECT-SPECIFIC PEDAGOGY TEXTS



SEMINAR DISCUSSIONS AND FEEDBACK OPPORTUNITIES

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Today gives you the map.

The next few weeks give you the tools.

The assignment asks you to decide
how and **why** you will use them.

